

Pentecostal and Charismatic Theology

A Biblical, Historical, and Pastoral Study of the Holy Spirit

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CTS Textbook Edition 2026.1

Preface

This textbook was prepared for students of Chapala Theological Seminary as an introduction to Pentecostal and Charismatic theology. It is written for an international and often bilingual student body, so the goal is clarity without oversimplification. The subject deserves both sympathy and scrutiny. Pentecostal and Charismatic Christians have made enormous contributions to prayer, mission, worship, evangelism, and the recovery of expectancy concerning the work of the Holy Spirit. The same broad movement has also contained serious abuses, including prosperity teaching, unaccountable leadership, exaggerated miracle claims, and spiritual manipulation. Fairness requires that neither side of that story be hidden.

The method of this book is Scripture first. Historical movements and contemporary experiences are examined seriously, but neither numbers nor experiences determine doctrine. At the same time, students are reminded that our interpretations are fallible. The church in Acts sometimes had to reconsider its expectations when God acted beyond familiar boundaries. The proper posture is therefore open to the Spirit and anchored in Scripture.

This is not a denominational recruitment text. Students are not required to become Pentecostal, Charismatic, or cessationist. They are required to read carefully, distinguish biblical text from theological inference, represent opposing positions fairly, and reach conclusions that can be defended from Scripture.

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1. The Question Before the Church

Pentecostal and Charismatic Christianity presents the wider church with a question that cannot responsibly be answered either by enthusiasm or dismissal: What should Christians expect the Holy Spirit to do among the people of God today? The question concerns tongues and prophecy, but it is much larger than either gift. It includes healing, guidance, revival, spiritual warfare, worship, mission, sanctification, and the ordinary work of the Spirit in forming Christian character.

The modern Pentecostal and Charismatic movements include hundreds of millions of Christians across many denominations and cultures. Their numerical size does not prove their theology, because truth is not determined by a census. Their scale does mean, however, that they cannot reasonably be treated as a marginal curiosity. A movement this widespread deserves careful biblical, historical, and pastoral examination, especially because much of its vitality now lies in Africa, Asia, and Latin America rather than in North America.

This book therefore begins with two commitments. First, Scripture is the final authority for Christian doctrine. Experience must be interpreted by Scripture rather than permitted to rewrite it. Second, our interpretations of Scripture are not themselves infallible. Acts repeatedly portrays God doing things that force faithful people to reconsider assumptions they had brought to the text. Cornelius did not change the Word of God; what happened in his house changed Peter's understanding of the reach of God's promise.

The resulting posture is neither credulity nor suspicion. Paul can say, in the same breath, that Christians must not quench the Spirit and that they must test everything. Those instructions belong together. The Christian who expects everything and tests nothing becomes gullible; the Christian who tests everything while expecting nothing may become closed to the very activity of God he professes to believe in.

The purpose of this study is therefore not to make students more Pentecostal or less Pentecostal. It is to help them become more biblical. We will listen carefully to Pentecostal, Charismatic, cessationist, Wesleyan, Baptist, and other Christian voices, while repeatedly returning to the text of Scripture. Where the evidence permits more than one responsible interpretation, that uncertainty will be acknowledged rather than concealed.

2. Pentecost: What Actually Happened?

Acts 2 must control any Christian discussion of Pentecost. The disciples are gathered when a sound like a violent wind fills the house, what appear to be tongues of fire rest upon them, and they are filled with the Holy Spirit. They begin speaking in other tongues as the Spirit enables them. Luke then moves immediately to the international crowd gathered in Jerusalem, and the emphasis becomes unmistakably linguistic: people from many regions hear the mighty works of God in their own languages.

The vocabulary strengthens that impression. Acts uses *glossa* for tongue or language, but the crowd also speaks of hearing in its own *dialektos*, its native language or dialect. The narrative does not present the event as meaningless sound. Whatever additional theological conclusions one draws, Acts 2 itself emphasizes intelligibility. Galileans are communicating across linguistic boundaries that normally would have prevented understanding.

The text also contains a notable hearing emphasis. The disciples speak, yet Luke repeatedly describes what the hearers experience: each hears in his own language. It is unnecessary to decide whether the miracle occurred exclusively in speaking or also involved extraordinary hearing. Luke's theological point is clearer than the mechanics. God enables the mighty works of God to be understood across the languages of the nations.

This makes Pentecost a striking counterpart to Babel. At Babel, human pride ends in confused speech and scattering. At Pentecost, God does not abolish languages or erase nations. Instead, the same gospel is heard through linguistic diversity. Pentecost reverses Babel not by creating one human language but by overcoming the barrier for the sake of God's mission. Diversity remains; understanding is given.

The manifestations are dramatic, but Luke does not permit them to become the center of the chapter. Peter stands and preaches Jesus. He interprets the event through Scripture, proclaims the crucified and risen Christ, confronts his hearers with their responsibility, and calls them to repentance. About three thousand are baptized. The new community devotes itself to apostolic teaching, fellowship, breaking bread, prayer, generosity, worship, and witness.

If we stop reading Acts 2 at the tongues, we miss much of Pentecost. Wind, fire, and languages announce something; the transformed community shows what the Spirit produces. This becomes an important test throughout this book. Extraordinary manifestations may deserve attention, but Christian awakening is finally evaluated by its relationship to Christ, truth, repentance, holiness, love, community, and mission.

3. The Spirit Crosses Boundaries

Acts does not repeat Pentecost in an identical pattern at every conversion. That variety is important. In Acts 8 the gospel reaches Samaritans, in Acts 10 it reaches the Gentile household of Cornelius, and in Acts 19 Paul encounters disciples associated with John the Baptist. At several major boundary crossings Luke records unusual manifestations of the Spirit.

Cornelius is especially important. The circumcised believers accompanying Peter are astonished that the gift of the Holy Spirit has been poured out even on Gentiles, because they hear them speaking in tongues and praising God. When Peter later defends his actions in Jerusalem, he says that the Spirit came upon the Gentiles as he had come upon the disciples at the beginning. His conclusion is practical and theological: if God gave them the same gift, Peter could not stand in God's way.

The episode raises a legitimate interpretive question. Are these narratives intended to establish an identical sequence for every Christian, or do some record extraordinary divine authentication as the gospel crosses decisive redemptive-historical boundaries? Classical Pentecostal interpreters have often emphasized the first possibility. Many non-Pentecostal interpreters emphasize the second. The text deserves better than deciding the answer before reading it.

Cornelius also teaches an important lesson about experience and interpretation. The experience does not overthrow Scripture. It does, however, force Peter and the Jerusalem church to reconsider how they had understood God's purposes. Scripture does not change, but human interpretation sometimes must. A church must never say that experience has proved Scripture wrong. It may sometimes have to say that what God has done has forced it to ask whether it understood Scripture correctly.

This distinction will recur throughout the book. Reports of healing, prophecy, dreams, tongues, or revival cannot create doctrine contrary to Scripture. Yet Christians should also be cautious about using a theological system to declare in advance what God is forbidden to do. The book of Acts contains too many surprised believers for that posture to be comfortable.

4. Gifts, Tongues, and the More Excellent Way

First Corinthians 12-14 provides the New Testament's most sustained treatment of spiritual gifts in congregational life. Paul does not write to a church lacking spiritual experience. Corinth appears to have an abundance of it. The problem is maturity, order, love, and edification.

Paul neither forbids tongues nor permits uncontrolled use. He can thank God that he speaks in tongues more than the Corinthians while also saying that in the church he would rather speak five intelligible words than ten thousand in a tongue. Public tongues are regulated: speakers are limited, they speak in turn, and interpretation is required. Without an interpreter the speaker is to remain quiet in the congregation. Prophecy is also evaluated rather than automatically accepted.

The relationship between Acts 2 and 1 Corinthians 14 is debated. Acts 2 plainly emphasizes recognizable languages. In Corinth, Paul says that the tongue-speaker speaks to God and is not understood by others. Pentecostal and Charismatic interpreters often understand this as a prayer language or supernatural utterance distinct from ordinary human language. Other interpreters argue that an actual human language unknown to the congregation would likewise be unintelligible without interpretation. The evidence warrants careful argument rather than ridicule from either side.

The placement of 1 Corinthians 13 is crucial. We often remove the chapter from its context and read it at weddings, where it is entirely appropriate. Paul, however, placed it between two chapters about spiritual gifts because Corinth needed a more fundamental measure of spirituality. Tongues without love are noise. Prophecy, knowledge, extraordinary faith, generosity, and even sacrifice become nothing when severed from love.

This is the more excellent way. Spiritual gifts are not decorations or ranks. They are gifts of grace intended for the good of the body. A spectacular gift does not establish spiritual superiority, and the absence of a disputed gift does not establish doctrinal maturity. The deeper question is what the Spirit is producing in the life of the believer and the community.

5. From Wesley to Azusa Street

Modern Pentecostalism did not suddenly appear in Kansas in 1901. It inherited theological questions and vocabulary that Christians had been developing for generations. The most important historical bridge runs through John Wesley and the nineteenth-century Holiness movement.

Wesley emphasized that conversion was not the end of Christian life. God intended believers to grow in holiness and love. Later Wesleyans often described a crisis experience subsequent to conversion using terms such as entire sanctification, second blessing, fullness of the Spirit, and baptism with the Holy Spirit. These expressions were not always used identically, but they created a framework in which Christians expected a significant work of grace beyond initial conversion.

Other nineteenth-century evangelical movements, including Keswick traditions, spoke about surrender, victorious Christian living, and power for service without necessarily adopting Wesleyan entire sanctification. Missionary expansion intensified the search for spiritual power. Christians asked whether the church could expect the kind of empowerment described in Acts as it carried the gospel throughout the world.

Charles Fox Parham emerged from this environment. At his Bible school in Topeka, Kansas, Parham and his students studied Acts while asking what evidence accompanied baptism in the Holy Spirit. The experience of Agnes Ozman around the beginning of 1901 became central to the developing doctrine that speaking in tongues constituted the initial physical evidence of Spirit baptism.

Some early Pentecostals initially expected these tongues to be actual foreign missionary languages. That expectation is historically understandable because Acts 2 was their model. Missionaries discovered, however, that alleged tongues generally did not function as usable foreign languages in the way they had expected. Pentecostal interpretation developed, increasingly describing tongues as Spirit-given utterance or prayer language rather than miraculous acquisition of ordinary foreign languages.

William J. Seymour carried the developing Pentecostal message to Los Angeles, where the Azusa Street revival began in 1906. Azusa became an extraordinary distribution point for Pentecostal spirituality and missionary activity. Its interracial worship under a Black pastor was striking in segregated America, although later Pentecostal history did not escape racial division. Seymour's increasing emphasis upon love also deserves attention. The history is richer than a story about tongues alone.

6. Spirit Baptism, Sanctification, and Christian Holiness

Pentecostalism inherited a difficult question from the Holiness movement: What is the relationship among conversion, sanctification, and baptism in the Holy Spirit? Different Pentecostal traditions answered differently. Some Holiness Pentecostals retained a three-stage pattern of conversion, entire sanctification, and Spirit baptism. Other Pentecostals understood sanctification more progressively and placed Spirit baptism directly after conversion.

Classical Pentecostal denominations commonly teach that tongues are the initial physical evidence of baptism in the Holy Spirit. They point to the pattern in Acts: tongues accompany the Spirit's coming at Pentecost, at Cornelius's house, and at Ephesus. At Cornelius's house, Peter's companions knew the Spirit had been given "for they heard them speak with tongues" (Acts 10:46). Other Christians answer that the pattern in Acts is not uniform, that the epistles never command every believer to speak in tongues as proof of receiving the Spirit, and that 1 Corinthians 12:30 asks, "Do all speak with tongues?" expecting the answer no. Pentecostals reply that Paul is describing the public gift of tongues in the congregation, not the initial sign of Spirit baptism. Students should weigh both the narrative pattern in Acts and the teaching of the epistles.

The New Testament is clearer on another point: every Christian has the Spirit. Paul says that anyone who does not have the Spirit of Christ does not belong to Christ. The Spirit is not an optional upgrade to Christianity. At the same time, people who already possess the Spirit can experience fresh filling and empowerment. Acts records believers being filled again, and Paul commands Christians to be filled with the Spirit. These truths need not be enemies.

Sanctification likewise contains both a present reality and continuing growth. Christians are set apart in Christ and genuinely transformed by the Spirit, yet they do not become sinless in this world. Paul speaks of pressing toward the goal while acknowledging that he has not already attained it. Christian holiness therefore rejects both complacency and perfectionism. Grace does not permit us to remain comfortably unchanged, but neither does spiritual growth justify claiming a perfection we have not reached.

The Christian hope is greater than endless improvement. John writes that when Christ appears, we shall be like him, because we shall see him as he is. Sanctification points toward glorification. We strive for the holiness of Christ throughout this life, dependent upon grace, confession, forgiveness, and the Spirit's continuing work. The final conformity for which we long belongs to the day when God's work in us is complete.

7. Revival: Manifestations and Fruit

Christian history contains awakenings marked by intense prayer, conviction, repentance, unusual emotion, and sometimes striking physical manifestations. Such history complicates easy arguments from both Pentecostal and non-Pentecostal sides. Unusual manifestations did not begin with twentieth-century Pentecostalism, but neither does their historical occurrence prove that every manifestation is divine.

The Kentucky revival associated with Cane Ridge in 1801 included reports of weeping, falling, trembling, crying aloud, and other physical responses. Christians disagreed about their meaning. That disagreement sounds surprisingly contemporary. Some responses may have reflected genuine conviction, others ordinary psychology and expectation, and some perhaps a mixture difficult to classify. The wise question is not merely what happened during the meeting but what followed it.

The Korean awakening of the early twentieth century provides a useful contrast because its most important manifestations were moral and communal. Prayer, confession of sin, restitution, reconciliation, Bible study, evangelism, and missionary concern became prominent. Such fruit does not require tongues to be recognized as the work of the Spirit. Pentecostals themselves should insist that the Holy Spirit was active long before modern Pentecostalism.

The South African revivals of the nineteenth century similarly remind us that Christians can pray for awakening and then become uncertain when the answer does not look as expected. Discomfort is not proof that God is absent, and novelty is not proof that God is present. Revival must be tested by biblical criteria: the centrality of Christ, fidelity to Scripture, repentance, holiness, prayer, love, reconciliation, mission, and enduring fruit.

Revival cannot be manufactured by reproducing the external features of an earlier awakening. All-night prayer, particular music, falling, tongues, prolonged invitations, or other features may accompany a movement of God, but description must not become a mechanical prescription. God is not a machine into which the church inserts the correct spiritual technique and receives revival.

8. Healing, Miracles, and Evidence

Christianity makes supernatural claims at its foundation. The resurrection of Jesus is not an optional ornament attached to an otherwise naturalistic religion. Christians therefore have no theological reason to declare miracles impossible in advance. At the same time, belief that God can perform miracles does not require believing every miracle story.

Testimony is evidence, but evidence varies in strength. A person reporting that a headache disappeared after prayer has described an experience worth receiving gratefully, but headaches frequently disappear. A well-documented medical condition that changes unexpectedly after prayer presents a different evidentiary situation. Responsible Christians can rejoice without exaggerating and investigate without cynicism.

The New Testament encourages prayer for the sick without promising that every faithful prayer will produce immediate healing. Paul knew extraordinary divine power and also knew suffering, weakness, and companions who became ill. Christian prayer therefore approaches God boldly but not presumptuously. Medicine and prayer are not competitors. Seeking competent medical care does not deny God's power, and praying does not require abandoning ordinary means of care.

Exaggerated miracle claims ultimately harm Christian witness. If an evangelist repeatedly announces healings that cannot withstand elementary investigation, skeptical people may conclude that all healing testimony is fraudulent. Truth does not need our assistance through exaggeration. If we know only that someone reported being healed, we should say that. If evidence confirms something extraordinary, we should say that. If we do not know, "we do not know" is a respectable Christian sentence.

Miracles also cannot authenticate false doctrine. An impressive experience does not transform greed into truth or place a teacher beyond biblical examination. The New Testament itself warns that extraordinary claims can accompany deception. Christians therefore investigate both the event and the teaching rather than allowing either enthusiasm or prior skepticism to decide the case automatically.

9. Prophecy, Guidance, Dreams, and "God Told Me"

Few expressions expose differences among Christians more quickly than the words, "God told me." Scripture unquestionably portrays God guiding people in extraordinary ways. Dreams, visions, prophetic messages, providential direction, and particular promptings all appear in the biblical narrative. Yet Scripture also warns repeatedly about false claims to divine speech.

A crucial distinction must therefore be maintained between biblical revelation and contemporary guidance. Scripture functions as the authoritative revelation by which doctrine and conduct are tested. A dream, impression, or prophecy cannot revise the gospel or make disobedience righteous. If someone says that God told him adultery is acceptable, no investigation of the experience is necessary; the message contradicts what God has already revealed.

Other claims belong to a different category. A Christian may feel strongly prompted to visit or pray for someone and later discover that the timing was remarkable. Christians may disagree about whether to describe the experience as direct guidance, providence, or an impression shaped by spiritual sensitivity. Nothing in such an experience creates doctrine for the church.

The phrase "God told me" becomes dangerous when used to control another person's conscience. A man who tells a woman that God has told him she must marry him has placed divine pressure upon her. A pastor who declares that disagreement with his plan is rebellion against God may be doing the same thing to a congregation. Humility is spiritually safer: "I believe God may be leading me this way, but I could be mistaken."

First Corinthians 14 itself requires evaluation of prophecy. The church is not told to accept a message simply because someone claims inspiration; others are to weigh what is said. Biblical Charismatic practice should therefore encourage discernment rather than suppress it.

Reports of dreams among Muslims who later become Christians provide a useful case study. The dream is not the gospel and does not establish Christian truth. If, however, a dream directs someone toward Jesus, Scripture, Christian witnesses, and ultimately the apostolic gospel, Christians need not rule out providential or supernatural guidance in advance. The experience must be interpreted by the gospel; the gospel must never be reconstructed around the experience.

10. Spiritual Warfare Without Superstition

The ministry of Jesus makes it difficult for Christians who accept the Gospels simply to remove demonic activity from their worldview. Jesus confronts evil spirits, commands them to leave, and gives his disciples authority over them. Acts also describes encounters with occult practices and spiritual opposition. Yet the New Testament does not develop the elaborate demonologies sometimes found in modern deliverance ministries.

Christians commonly distinguish demonic possession from demonic oppression. The exact English terminology is not a technical biblical classification, but the distinction expresses an important pastoral truth. The Gospels portray severe cases in which evil spirits exercise extraordinary control. Believers, meanwhile, are warned about temptation, accusation, deception, persecution, and spiritual attack. Scripture calls Christians to vigilance without portraying them as uncertain property whose ownership shifts between Christ and demons.

The Christian belongs to Christ. John writes that the one who is in believers is greater than the one who is in the world. James tells Christians to resist the devil, and Peter tells them to stand firm in faith. Paul describes believers as transferred from the dominion of darkness into Christ's kingdom. Spiritual attack is possible; spiritual terror is unnecessary.

This becomes especially important in cultures where curses, witchcraft, hexes, ancestral spirits, or occult powers are feared. The gospel must not simply replace one system of fear with a Christianized version of the same system. A convert who once feared a curse should not spend the rest of his Christian life desperately seeking specialists to break hidden curses. Christianity does not defeat witchcraft by providing stronger witchcraft. Prayer is not a Christian spell, and the name of Jesus is not a magical formula.

The same balance applies to claims of possession. The Gospels distinguish demonic activity from illness, and responsible ministry should do the same. Epilepsy, mental illness, neurological disorders, trauma, addiction, and ordinary human sin are real. Spiritual evil is also real. Christians should neither dismiss every spiritual claim as superstition nor interpret every poorly understood condition as demonic. Prayer and competent medical or psychological care need not compete.

Teaching about generational curses requires similar care. Sin can produce consequences across generations through violence, addiction, abuse, learned behavior, poverty, trauma, and damaged relationships. Scripture nevertheless emphasizes personal moral responsibility, and the New Testament places the believer's identity in Christ. Christians may inherit consequences and patterns requiring serious discipleship and healing; they should not be taught that an ancestral spiritual ownership claim survives union with Christ until a specialist discovers the correct ritual.

11. Prosperity, Power, and the Testing of Ministries

One of the gravest dangers accompanying parts of the Pentecostal and Charismatic world is prosperity teaching. The problem is not that Christians believe God blesses his people or answers prayer. Scripture contains abundant testimony to God's generosity. The problem arises when blessing becomes a predictable financial mechanism and God is treated as though he were obligated to enrich those who use the correct spiritual formula.

The New Testament does not present Jesus as a prosperity preacher. He calls disciples to take up a cross. Paul knows both abundance and need, and his famous statement that he can do all things through Christ belongs to that context of contentment rather than to a promise of unlimited achievement. Generosity is Christian obedience, not an investment contract by which a donor purchases a larger return from God.

Prosperity teaching can be especially attractive in communities facing poverty, illness, and insecurity. That attraction should be understood compassionately rather than mocked. People want hope. Yet precisely because vulnerable people have so much at stake, Christian leaders carry a greater responsibility not to exploit their desperation.

The New Testament provides practical tests for ministry. Does the teaching exalt Christ? Is it consistent with Scripture? What kind of fruit appears in the lives of leaders and followers? Is financial practice transparent? Are the weak protected or exploited? Can leaders be questioned? Does the movement produce repentance, generosity, and service, or does it continually direct attention toward the wealth and authority of the minister?

Claims such as "touch not the Lord's anointed" must never be used to place leaders beyond accountability. In the New Testament, prophets are evaluated, teachers are judged by their doctrine and fruit, and even apostolic claims are examined. Spiritual authority is responsibility under Christ, not immunity from examination.

12. The Global Church: Africa, Latin America, and Iran

The center of gravity of world Christianity has shifted dramatically toward the Global South, and Pentecostal and Charismatic forms of Christianity are deeply involved in that change. Western Christians therefore need to resist the temptation to evaluate the entire movement by a handful of American personalities. The questions raised by African, Latin American, and Asian churches are often different from those that dominate Western theological debates.

In many African contexts, traditional worldviews take spiritual realities seriously. Ancestors, spirits, curses, witchcraft, possession, protection, and ritual practices may be understood as part of ordinary life. Western missionaries can arrive affirming demons doctrinally while having little practical preparation for people who believe they encounter spiritual powers directly. Pentecostal Christianity often speaks immediately to that world by proclaiming that spiritual evil is real and that Jesus is Lord over it.

That strength can become a weakness if spiritual warfare turns into obsession. The gospel should liberate people from fear, not teach them to fear a larger catalog of spirits. The New Testament takes evil seriously without making Satan the center of Christian attention. Jesus' encounters with demons are ultimately stories about the authority of Jesus.

Latin America likewise demonstrates both the vitality and the dangers of Pentecostal expansion. Churches have often grown through energetic lay participation, local leadership, prayer, healing ministries, and flexible structures that require few institutional resources. The same environment can also permit weak accountability, prosperity teaching, and excessive authority in individual leaders. Growth deserves attention but does not eliminate discernment.

Iran provides a particularly challenging contemporary case. Reports from underground Christian networks describe significant growth under difficult conditions, substantial participation by women, and forms of spirituality that may include dreams, visions, healing, prayer, and perceived divine guidance. Precise numbers are difficult to establish in an underground movement, and not every Iranian Christian should be described as Charismatic. The case nevertheless forces Western Christians to examine whether they celebrate reports of growth while quietly ignoring features that do not fit their expectations.

No regional example proves a theology. Sociology can often explain mechanisms of growth through networks, migration, indigenous leadership, cultural adaptation, and community formation. Such explanations do not necessarily settle the theological question. Christians can ask both how a movement grew and whether the Spirit of God was at work through those human processes.

13. Did the Gifts Cease?

Cessationists are sometimes caricatured as Christians who do not believe in miracles. Many actually believe strongly that God heals, answers prayer, guides providentially, and can perform extraordinary acts. Their narrower claim is that certain gifts associated with the apostolic era, particularly prophecy, tongues, and gifts of healing, served a foundational purpose and should not be expected as continuing congregational gifts throughout the church age.

The strongest cessationist argument begins with the uniqueness of the apostles and the foundational character of apostolic revelation. Ephesians describes the church as built upon the foundation of apostles and prophets, and Paul refers to signs associated with apostolic ministry. Once that foundation and authoritative apostolic witness were established, cessationists argue, revelatory and sign gifts no longer served the same purpose. The concern is often the sufficiency and finality of Scripture rather than hostility to divine power.

Continuationists respond with a comparatively simple question: Where does the New Testament clearly say that these gifts will cease before Christ returns? Paul tells churches to desire spiritual gifts, regulates prophecy and tongues, and explicitly says not to forbid speaking in tongues. Peter interprets Pentecost through Joel's promise concerning the last days, including prophecy, visions, and dreams. Continuationists therefore see no clear biblical expiration date.

First Corinthians 13 has sometimes been used to argue that gifts ceased when the New Testament canon was completed, but the language of seeing face to face and knowing fully appears more naturally to point toward the consummation than toward the completion of a collection of books. That observation does not by itself prove continuationism; it does mean that this particular cessationist argument carries less weight than is sometimes claimed.

Church history is also complicated. Reports of healing, visions, prophecy, unusual manifestations, and phenomena resembling tongues appear after the apostolic period, but so do fraud, fanaticism, and superstition. Historical occurrence cannot by itself establish biblical legitimacy, and historical absence would not necessarily prove theological cessation. Scripture remains primary; history can complicate our assumptions without replacing exegesis.

14. The Spirit and the Mission of God

Acts 1:8 connects the Spirit with mission: the disciples will receive power and become witnesses from Jerusalem outward to the ends of the earth. Pentecost immediately demonstrates the relationship. The Spirit is poured out, Christ is proclaimed, people respond, and the gospel begins crossing boundaries.

This missionary dimension helps explain part of Pentecostalism's global vitality. Pentecostal churches have often expected ordinary believers to participate actively in ministry. A Christian may pray for the sick, share the gospel, begin a Bible study, or help establish a congregation without waiting for advanced academic credentials. That expectation can release enormous missionary energy.

The danger is obvious when theological formation is neglected. Enthusiasm without knowledge can produce shallow doctrine, authoritarian leaders, prosperity teaching, and interpretations built more upon testimony than Scripture. Yet the opposite danger is also real. Churches can educate people so thoroughly for ministry that they spend years preparing to do what the earliest Christians began doing almost immediately. The New Testament does not require a choice between theological depth and missionary urgency.

A seminary must therefore avoid two failures. It must not reduce God to an academic subject, producing students capable of analyzing the Holy Spirit while rarely depending upon him. It must also refuse confident ignorance masquerading as spirituality. The Holy Spirit is not threatened by scholarship, and scholarship should not be threatened by the Holy Spirit.

Good theological education should form Christians who can examine a difficult text carefully and pray sincerely, investigate a miracle claim without cynicism and reject a fraudulent one without embarrassment, recognize medical or psychological realities while remaining biblically open to spiritual realities, and evaluate claimed prophecy without automatically accepting or dismissing it.

15. Open to the Spirit, Anchored in Scripture

The Spirit's work has a destination. He gives gifts, empowers witness, guides the church, assists believers in prayer, produces fellowship, and sometimes acts in ways that surprise God's people. Yet all of these activities belong to a larger purpose: God is forming a people who increasingly resemble Jesus Christ.

This provides a final standard for evaluating spirituality. A congregation may be expressive or quiet, continuationist or cessationist, liturgical or spontaneous. Its members may raise their hands, kneel silently, speak in tongues, or never witness tongues at all. None of those characteristics alone establishes spiritual maturity. The fruit of the Spirit takes us deeper because it describes the character God is producing.

Disagreement about the Spirit can become unusually personal because Christians are often debating experiences as well as propositions. A Pentecostal may describe an experience that transformed prayer and devotion. A non-Pentecostal may question the interpretation without needing to declare the experience fraudulent. Likewise, a Pentecostal has no warrant for treating a believer who has never spoken in tongues as spiritually inferior. Experience and interpretation should be distinguished, and humility should govern disputed cases.

Paul's instruction remains a fitting summary: do not quench the Spirit, test everything, and hold fast to what is good. Some Christians especially need the first command because practical expectation of divine action has become small. Others especially need the second because eagerness for experience has made them vulnerable to manipulation and error. Biblical Christianity requires both openness and discernment.

Any theology of the Holy Spirit that pushes Jesus toward the margins has gone wrong. The Spirit glorifies Christ. Peter's Spirit-empowered sermon proclaims Christ. Gifts build Christ's body. The fruit of the Spirit forms Christlike character. When a movement increasingly revolves around the prophet, healer, apostle, pastor, or celebrity through whom manifestations supposedly occur, the center has shifted.

The Pentecostal Christian must be willing to ask whether enthusiasm has sometimes substituted for discernment. The non-Pentecostal Christian must ask whether discernment has sometimes become a respectable name for expecting very little from God. The prosperity preacher must confront the cross, the cessationist must confront Acts, the Pentecostal must confront Corinthians, and every Christian must confront Jesus.

We should therefore pray boldly and test carefully, expect God to act without pretending that every unusual event is his action, resist spiritual evil without fearing it, pursue gifts without making them measures of spiritual superiority, seek holiness without claiming sinless perfection, and listen respectfully to Christians whose experiences differ from our own.

Above all, the Spirit who was poured out at Pentecost is forming a people for Christ. His work in us remains unfinished. We stumble, misunderstand, disagree, repent, learn, and continue toward a holiness we have not yet attained. The promise remains

that when Christ appears, we shall be like him, for we shall see him as he is. That is the destination toward which the Spirit is leading the church.

Selected Bibliography and Source Notes

The works below informed this textbook. Historical sources are listed with their original publication details. Statistics on global and underground Christianity change quickly and vary by definition, so any figure should be read as a dated estimate.

Bible. New King James Version (NKJV).

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Crockett, Horace Leeds. *Conversations on "The Tongues."* Louisville, KY: Pentecostal Publishing Company, 1929. Holiness critique of the early tongues movement.

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Note: In Morrison's and Crockett's day, "Pentecostal" was a common Holiness word for the experience of entire sanctification, not for speaking in tongues. Their publisher's name does not mean they belonged to the later Pentecostal movement; Crockett in fact wrote against it.

Wesley, John. *A Plain Account of Christian Perfection*. 1766.

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Reports on Christianity in Africa, Latin America, and Iran. Because underground-church statistics are inherently uncertain, numerical claims should be dated and qualified.

Editorial Note

This textbook was developed for Chapala Theological Seminary under the author's theological direction. Digital research, translation, drafting, and editorial tools were used in its preparation. The author reviewed and assumes responsibility for the theological positions and final content. This CTS textbook is an original instructional synthesis. Public-domain historical works may be excerpted or adapted in later course editions with clear attribution. Where material is substantially abridged or modernized, the edition should identify it as abridged and edited or adapted and abridged rather than presenting altered wording as the original author's text. Contemporary copyrighted scholarship should be summarized and cited rather than reproduced at length.